

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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DJIA 42635.20 ▲ 106.84 0.25% NASDAQ 19478.88 ▼ 0.1% STOXX 600 513.67 ▼ 0.2% 10-YR. TREAS. (Reopening) yield 4.691% OIL \$73.32 ▼ \$0.93 GOLD \$2,664.50 ▲ \$7.80 EURO \$1.0320 YEN 158.36

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **U.S. dockworkers** and shipping companies reached a tentative labor deal, capping a contentious contract battle and averting a strike at major ports that threatened to rattle the U.S. economy. **B1**

◆ **John Malone's** Liberty Media appointed board member and seasoned sports executive Derek Chang as its new chief executive and president effective Feb. 1. **B1**

◆ **Billionaire Leon Black** is in talks to become the anchor investor behind the planned purchase of the U.K.'s Daily Telegraph newspaper. **B1**

◆ **U.S. stocks** were mixed in a session led by swings in U.S. Treasury yields, with the S&P 500 and Dow gaining 0.2% and 0.3%, respectively, and the Nasdaq slipping less than 0.1%. The yield on the 10-year Treasury note rose to 4.691%. **B11**

◆ **Fed officials** saw risks of higher-than-expected inflation when they made a "finely balanced" decision last month to cut interest rates, minutes show. **A2**

◆ **Tencent bought back** shares in an expansive move that should support their price after the company's appearance on a Pentagon list triggered a heavy selloff. **B1**

◆ **Albertsons executives** conducting an earnings call for the first time in more than two years presented plans to eliminate about \$1.5 billion in costs over the next three years. **B3**

◆ **The U.K. competition** regulator said it could approve chip-design firm Synopsys's \$35 billion purchase of Ansys after the companies offered to sell business units to ease the agency's concerns. **B4**

World-Wide

◆ **At least five people** were killed and tens of thousands were forced to evacuate as wildfires devastated the Los Angeles area and stretched the region's firefighting resources to its limits. **A1**

◆ **The property damage** toll won't be calculated for days or weeks, and the severity for residents may be exacerbated by a deepening home-insurance crisis. **A1**

◆ **The fires are being driven** by the dry, fast-moving Santa Ana winds that blow from the inland deserts of California and Nevada to the Pacific Ocean. **A4**

◆ **The leader of the** Panama Canal Authority denied Trump's claim that China controls the vital trade route, and said the president-elect's suggestion that U.S. ships get preferential rates "will lead to chaos." **A3**

◆ **Trump asked** the Supreme Court to block his coming New York sentencing for covering up hush money paid to an adult-film star. **A3**

◆ **A U.S. Senate** panel accused private-equity healthcare investors of choosing profits over patient care, adding a prominent voice to those claiming that Wall Street is jeopardizing the medical system. **A6**

◆ **Iran released** Italian journalist Cecilia Sala, whose arrest in Tehran last month sparked fears of a lengthy hostage crisis. **A16**

◆ **Israel's military** said it retrieved the body of a hostage held in Gaza and said it found evidence that raised serious concerns about the life of the man's son held in the enclave. **A7**

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Raging Fires Ravage Los Angeles

Five dead, 130,000 ordered to flee, 2,000 buildings burned as wind-whipped flames sweep neighborhoods



Much of the Los Angeles neighborhood of Pacific Palisades was left reduced to ashes and rubble Wednesday after fires swept through.

LOS ANGELES—At least five people were killed and tens of thousands were forced to evacuate as wildfires devastated

By Jennifer Calfas,
Gareth Vipers
and Sarah Krouse

the Los Angeles area. One wind-fueled fire tore through the affluent oceanside Pacific Palisades neighborhood

while another, responsible for all of the deaths, burned in and around Pasadena to the east of Los Angeles. Portions of Hollywood were ordered to evacuate Wednesday evening as a new fire broke out in the hills above the center of the city.

At least 2,000 structures were damaged or destroyed, including two elementary schools and part of a high school that were consumed by

flames, officials said. Hollywood studios stopped production, movie premieres were canceled, schools and tourist attractions closed and a Los Angeles Kings hockey game was postponed.

The unprecedented scale of the fires was a result of a combination of deadly weather conditions—hurricane-force winds and tinder-dry brush.

"This is the worst one I've

seen," said Tim McKeon, a 24-year veteran of the Los Angeles Fire Department, who paused for a break Wednesday morning in Santa Monica.

"By the time we got to a house and put the fire out, the fire had spread to three or four other houses," McKeon said. The wind was so strong that it blew hose streams away from their targets, he said.

The two largest fires, the

Eaton fire in the Pasadena area and the Palisades fire, were completely uncontained Wednesday night. More than 27,000 acres were on fire. At least 130,000 residents in the Los Angeles area are under evacuation orders, and more than 28,000 homes, businesses

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◆ **Santa Ana winds drive Los Angeles-area fires.....** A4

‘Get Out, Get Out Now’

By JIM CARLTON
AND SARA RANDAZZO

LOS ANGELES—The fire rose from the bone-dry hills, as so many others have, and then rapidly tore across the coast and hills of one of America's most famous cities—oblivious to the demographics of the lives it disrupted. It burned

mansions in Malibu and low-income housing in Pasadena.

And after more than a day, the reality was setting in that it isn't even close to over.

Paul Hirsch, 79 years old, felt this one was different. At his home perched above the ocean, the wind gusts were so much stronger this time. He scrambled to stow his collec-

tion of paintings in a fireproof vault at his home on Las Pulgas Place, in the Pacific Palisades area of L.A.'s west side. After an hour or so of emails and texts from others urging him to leave—as well as a ring on his doorbell—he and his wife, Jane, also 79, piled into their car Tuesday and headed down the hill toward what they thought

would be an orderly evacuation route on Sunset Boulevard.

Ash rained down on their car and he could see flames next to the street as they wound their way through gridlock to the Pacific Coast Highway and on to refuge with relatives. In the commotion, Hirsch realized he had left something important be-

hind: a tuxedo he was to wear to accept a lifetime achievement award Jan. 18 from the American Cinema Editors for his work as an Oscar-winning film editor.

"I guess I'll go in bluejeans or something," Hirsch said.

Multiple Los Angeles fires burning out of control are

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Xi Muzzles Economist In Drive To Silence Criticism

By LINGLING WEI

A prominent Chinese economist raised doubts about Beijing's economic management at a Washington forum in December and said China's economy might have grown at less than half the roughly 5% pace flaunted by authorities.

When Xi Jinping found out, he was furious.

People familiar with the matter said the Chinese leader ordered an investigation of Gao Shanwen, chief economist at state-owned SDIC Securities, who has frequently advised the government on economic and financial policies. Xi then ordered authorities to discipline him.

Two comments that Gao made at the forum, hosted jointly by the Peterson Institute for International Economics and a Chinese think tank, angered Xi, the people said.

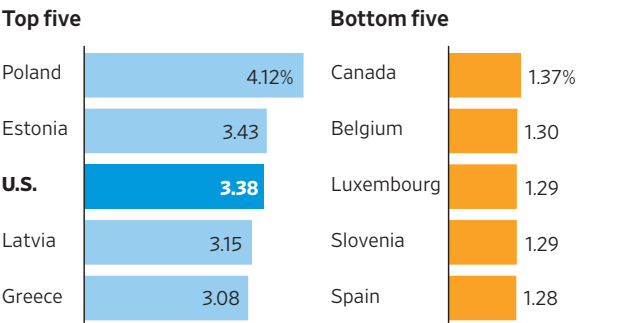
One questioned the reliability of Chinese growth data. "We do not know the true number of China's real growth figure," Gao said at the Dec. 12 event, whose webcast is available on the Peterson Institute's website and on YouTube. "My own specula-

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Demands Shake Up NATO

President-elect Donald Trump's latest call for members of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization to boost their defense spending is raising concerns about the alliance's strength. **A3**

Highest and lowest defense-spending NATO members in 2024, as a percentage of GDP



Note: Data are estimates.

Source: NATO

Musk Finds Time To Reach a Videogame Milestone

The head of six companies says he is one of world's best players of 'Diablo IV'

By SARAH E. NEEDLEMAN
AND BECKY PETERSON

This past fall, Elon Musk unveiled Tesla's new robotaxi, launched dozens of rockets and spent weeks campaigning



Multitasking

The billionaire declared himself one of the world's best players of "Diablo IV," a block-

buster videogame set in a dark fantasy realm that involves making elixirs and slaying demons.

"So many life lessons to be learned from speedrunning video games on max difficulty," Musk wrote on his social-media platform X on Nov. 20, before going on to announce that he'd just cleared

the highest tier of a section of the game called "The Pit" in under two minutes. He in-

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Riches, Routes Draw Trump to Greenland

By GEORGI KANTCHEV

President-elect Donald Trump has set his sights on a vast, ice-covered and sparsely populated island with a strategic location on the edge of the Arctic—and a whole lot of mineral riches.

At more than three times the size of Texas, Greenland's ample deposits in rare earths, oil and gas, as well as its commanding position astride crucial trade and military arteries, have made it a focal point

for major rival powers including the U.S., China and Russia.

Greenland's rising profile reflects the larger global scramble for the Arctic as climate change opens maritime routes and reorders geopolitics at the top of the world. Russia reopened dozens of Soviet military bases in the Arctic as tensions with the West worsened over the invasion of Ukraine. China has pursued expanding shipping routes through the region's melting

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Coal-Mine Magnate Bet Big, Won Big

Low Tuck Kwong ignored warnings about the future of the grimy fossil fuel

By JON EMONT

TABANG, Indonesia—Deep in Indonesian Borneo, workers laid asphalt on a new 60-mile road being built to transport coal from mines that have never been busier.

At one end of the road, crews built a 40-foot-high conveyor belt that whisks the coal over swampland to a new jetty on the Mahakam River. From there, the coal is

funneled onto barges and floated downstream to a private port on the Pacific Ocean. Giant loading machines fill equally massive ships headed for China, India and the Philippines.

Coal, the world's dirtiest fossil fuel, is booming, and few are profiting more than Low Tuck Kwong, the 76-year-old businessman behind one of Asia's largest coal-

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